Bai was the most powerful of Maharaja Rai Singh's wives and used her influence to secure the throne for her son. The ranis had their own set of staff, loyal to them, known collectively by the name of the rani, such as Bhattiyaniji ki sarkar, who carried out the work under her supervision. Like the Mughals, the rajmata was often the most powerful woman of the zenana, acquiring more influence as a queen mother than she ever did as a wife. These women often owned land in their own names, the haath-kharach jagir, which they controlled through administrators. Agents kept these ranis informed about conditions in their jagirs, 'the state of agriculture, famine, law and order, or social problems'—such as those related to the peasantry and so on. In a few years' time, Harkha Bai would be similarly kept informed about the state of indigo cultivation in her own jagir, and she would send agents to buy the precious harvests, at one stage getting into a confrontation with Portuguese buyers, which would have rather dire consequences for the Portuguese.

Articulating the fine-grained imagery of these complicated personas was the *Mancarit*, a biography of Raja Man Singh written in a mixture of Brajbhasha and Rajasthani by Amrit Rai. In one part of the *Mancarit*, Amrit Rai deals with the genealogy of the Mughal Padshah using unassailable Hindu imagery:

> Born in the lineage of Timur, the son of Humayun
> Is revered in the three worlds by heroic men
> He is a portion of the supreme being (avatara) descended to earth
> To destroy the suffering of others
> He is the rightful universal emperor of the Chaghatay clan
> A protector of the entire earth
> Long live Shah Jahal al din the world conqueror
> The Jewel of the World.

The *Mancarit* was just one of a profusion of writings in Rajasthani and Brajbhasha dialects that were produced at the regional courts in the late sixteenth century. Indeed the Kachhwaha court at Amer has been deemed crucial by scholars in the genesis of Riti literature.[*] The Kachhwahas did not usually patronize Persian literature but instead supported Rajasthani and Riti styles of writing, sometimes in addition to Sanskrit. Mostly ignored by Abu'l Fazl and the Mughal records because of the preference given to Persian texts, these manuscripts offer fascinating insights into the ways in